

India at work

India's answer to Amazon, Infibeam also has a range of ebooks and an ebook reader the Pi that displays several Indian languages

Wink

EC Media, another Indian company has also launched the Wink reader that supports English, Hindi, Malayalam and Marathi

READING REDEFINED



Nash David

nash.david@thinkdigit.com

“The man who does not read good books has no advantage over the man who can’t read them.”
- Mark Twain



Knowledge has been regarded as the epitome of power, for as long as we can remember. In fact, most modern day thinkers advocate technology for the very sake of advancement, with the genesis of the idea lying in *better* knowledge. Ever since Gutenberg printed the Bible on his press in 1439, generations have been transformed. The most significant one being the abolishment of slavery in the United States owing to the advocacy of freedom, liberty and equality. Since the days of Gutenberg and his revolutionary press, the printing and publishing industry has witnessed a phenomenal growth, spiralling over centuries. Flipping through the ages (and pages) and stepping into our era, the internet has enfolded the business of knowledge with its vast web.

In our age, information has been available through waves, wires and of course, the all inclusive web. It's hard to think of a life void of these three. The love of reading while tanning has sustained a thriving industry now witnessing downward spirals in its DNA. If the w3 we spoke of wasn't enough, there's eBooks.

We all know what happened to the paging industry not too long ago. A text-only means of communication could never sustain itself with a much better conglomerate of voice, data, text and video at lower costs. With books, we're witnessing a similar scenario.

To satiate your thirst for knowledge, and especially reading, the latest offering is that of eBook readers. The idea is to be able to read a digital copy (PDF, TXT or the rather secure ePub) of your favourite

novel or book using dedicated hardware. This concept was popularised by Amazon with its classic Kindle Reader in 2007. In the three years of its business in this product category, Amazon has revamped the Kindle through 3 generations. The current one being Kindle 3 announced in July this year. It's slimmer, faster and cheaper than the earlier models.

Consumer leanings

E-ink is indeed pleasant to read. Digit community member Sanket Naik believes in urban India, space and storage of a book collection is a major concern. Due to space constraints, he prefers eBook readers to print. Also, he finds it uncomfortable to read more than 20 pages at one stretch on a laptop or LCD display. That's one of the highlights and advantage of e-ink.

Another Digit reader, Milind Shah prefers software and apps for mobile and smartphone platforms (BlackBerry, Android, iPhone), iPad and PC, rather than buying an eBook reader. According to Shah, “with these apps, you no longer need an ebook reader. This does away with the need for paper”. Effectively, is the transition from paper to eBooks really worth it? One major concern is the effect of paper production on the environment. Another Digit reader says she doesn't need another gadget to spoil her eyes and rather prefers good old books with paper.

Market research findings

Echoing the growing concern to the print and publishing industry is Forrester Research with its report that recommends “strategists planning the next wave of ebook readers diversify the portfolio of eReading devices to secure their ownership of the reading experience, offering devices that range from stripped-down \$49 pocket readers to full-color touch readers that erase the gap between today's ebook readers and tablet PCs.” Clearly, the single largest threat to eBook Readers appears to be in the form of tablet PCs, at least for now. But, a ₹1,500 ebook reader – really?

Eventually, there's one question that still dodges us. Why use eBook readers – for convenience, cost or charm? In the